

Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL



### DREAM CITY: The new skyline of Bhuj with entertainment parks and high-rise housing instead of desert

the fact that the number of cars in the district has almost quadrupled in seven years. Apart from Bhuj, which had an airport, Kandla has a new airport now. Against the solitary Indian airlines flight to Bhuj the two airports get five flights from Mumbai every day besides one from Ahmedabad. Says industrialist Gautam Adani, the biggest investor in the district: "That adversity has to give way to success holds completely true in the case of Kutch. The success story of Kutch has just begun. It still has unlimited growth potential". Locals who normally went to big cities like Ahmedabad for jobs, now find it on their doorstep. Jit Gor, son of a wholesale fruit seller of Bhuj who did his MBA recently, has landed a good job right next to Bhuj in Asian Motor Works a Rs 1,000 crore company that manufactures trucks. It came to Kutch after the earthquake. Says Gor: "I could scarcely imagine that I would get as decent a job right next to my house."

starting business in my homeland but could not find a suitable opportunity. That opportunity has come in ways more than I could expect."

Bhuj is a symbol of the transformation of Kutch. The medieval city known for poor infrastructure is suddenly a bustling place marked by superb infrastructure with excellent roads, traffic points, gardens and modern housing colonies. The beautiful Hill Garden built on a hill on Bhuj's outskirts exemplifies the turnaround. Another example is Jhadva, a village of 300 people in Abdasa taluka. The village, comprising shepherds, had little economic activity. Today, it earns Rs 6,000 a day by selling 400 litres of milk to local industry. About 70 youths from the village are employed in factories.

An idea of the economic prosperity that has embraced Kutch comes from

Until the earthquake there were just five industrial training institutes (ITIs) in Kutch. Today there are 10. Take the example of the ITI in Bhuj. It had just four trades and 80 seats earlier. Today it has 18 trades and 600 seats and there is a constant demand from the industrial units to train their personnel in special trades. The Tatas have indicated to the ITIs that they will need around 1,200 skilled personnel for their upcoming power unit at Mundra. Says J.P. Chotia, principal of ITI at Bhuj: "There is a great demand for trained welders, fitters and automobile hands and it is only growing."

The scenario for the craftsmen of Kutch, who are known for their excellence in fields like embroidery and vegetable colour printing is improving every day. Says Niranjana Shah, an exporter of Kutchi handicrafts, "The

earthquake relief work meant more exposure of the Kutchi handicrafts before outsiders, particularly foreigners who had come as part of rehabilitation efforts. And that had meant enhanced sales. Says Meera Goradia, of the Crafts Resource Centre, an NGO helping Kutchi craftsmen: "Things are truly bright for most craftsmen of Kutch. In fact, Kutch is a brand now when it comes to crafts, particularly those to do with textiles." "Shah estimates that the annual Kutch handicraft business has doubled.

According to Maheshwar Sahu, a joint secretary with the Union Government who was actively involved in the rehabilitation efforts after the earthquake, Kutch owes its unbelievable rise to a unique model of public-private partnership where the Government floated policies and schemes after consulting the locals and the NGOs working in diverse sectors. Says Sahu: "The famed resilience of the Kutchis was of course one of the main factors but the public-private partnership model that developed following the earthquake was a greater factor". What has come as a boon in all this is the Narmada water that now comes to Kutch from a distance of over 500 km through canal and pipelines in what is a feat of engineering. Also, Kutch, which normally gets scanty rainfall, has been receiving moderate to good rainfall in the past five years.

The winds of change blowing in Kutch came to the fore recently in Tundwadh village where models exhibited the textiles produced by local Kutchi craftswomen in a fashion show held in the presence of members of the Crafts Council of India. The models displayed the garments with the famous Kutchi embroidery work and also walked the ramp with Kutchi designers in the form of rural Kutchi women. It was a rare sight and truly symbolised the incredible turnaround of Kutch. ■



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